exchanged for the IC 814 hostages; Ghazi Baba, alleged chief of Jaish operations in J&K; and Tariq Ahmed, a Kashmiri. The Supreme Court acknowledged that Afzal was neither the mastermind nor the executor of the Parliament attack, and that it had no direct evidence but only circumstantial evidence to prove Afzal's guilt as a conspirator. The Parliament attack was a serious and unprecedented crime and Afzal's sensational arrest two days after the attack, his trial and subsequent debates on the death sentence all serve to divert attention away from the crime itself.

On 13 December 2001, an Ambassador with five armed men entered the Parliament premises while it was in session. The security personnel apprehended the car and in the exchange of gunfire that lasted for thirty minutes, all five terrorists were killed. Seven policemen on duty at the time also lost their lives. Considering the enormity of the attack and the fact that we nearly went to war with Pakistan, the Home Ministry, in a departure from all norms (where the CBI would investigate such a case), named ACP Rajbir Singh of Delhi Police as Investigating Officer. And who was this man? A self-proclaimed encounter specialist, who later conducted the dubious Ansal Plaza encounter and was finally disgraced with charges of corruption when he attempted to blackmail a couple of west Delhi businessmen.

Not surprisingly, the Parliament attack investigation was completed in a record seventeen days. But with the Supreme Court setting aside Afzal's confessional statement as unreliable, there is nothing else that confirms the sequence of events or the conspiracy theory linking the masterminds with Afzal. Who were the attackers? Who were the masterminds? What was the conspiracy? Five years after the Parliament attack the Indian public still doesn't know the truth and seems to be content to hang a man, close the case and sweep the rest under the carpet.

Afzal's own statement recorded by the courts blows holes in the police version, and yet the honourable judges have selectively ignored the startling revelations. According to Afzal he joined the JKLF in 1990 but was disillusioned and surrendered before the BSF in 1993. As the courts noted, Afzal had to regularly report to the Special Task Force (STF) as per laws governing surrendered militants. Regarding Tariq Ahmad, named by the prosecution as one of the masterminds, Afzal says that it was at an STF camp that he was introduced to Ahmad. As for Mohammad, the terrorist killed in the attack, Afzal says that Tariq took him to meet the DSP of Humhuma Chowk, Davinder Singh, who then introduced him to Mohammad. Singh